Escape the House: Design Statement

Game Idea and Mechanic

"Escape the House" is a top-down view horror game built around one rule that noise is a resource. The player wakes trapped in an abandoned house while a creature hunts for the player. For the player to escape they must find a key and reach the exit before getting caught. My prototype is purposely a boxed room in Unity with cover objects, one creature, one key and one door so testers react to the mechanic and not the art.

The player can walk or sprint. Walking is silent but slow. Sprinting is twice as fast but loud. The creature can hear it from a set distance away. Sprinting also runs on a meter that lasts for two seconds and draining it fully locks the player out of sprinting for 3 seconds.

The creature has three states. The first is patrolling the creature moves between points in the room. If it hears a sprint, it will start investigating by walking to the source of the noise and walking around. If the player enters the creatures vision cone, which walls and furniture block it will start chasing. After 3 seconds without seeing the player, it gives up and goes back to patrolling. The chase speed is in the middle of the players walking speed and sprinting speeds. This means a spotted player must either sprint and make noise or break the line of sight behind some cover.

Design Rationale

I chose this mechanic because it turns movement, which is a basic verb in a game into a decision. A decision is only interesting when each option has a cost. Tying noise and speed together means that moves trade safety for time. The speeds are purposely tuned so that neither

option can dominate. Always walking will get you caught when you are seen and always sprinting alerts the creature and empties your sprint meter at the moment.

Stealth also works if people can read the enemy. They need to predict what the creature might do so the creature's state is shown by its color. A yellow creature heading to the players position tells them it heard something but does not know where they are. "Mark of the Ninja" inspired me with their rings for my noise ring. When players get caught it should feel fair.

The mechanic also depends on being digital. The rules are continuous and spatial. Hearing is a distance check against a radius, and the sight part combines distance, angle and an unblocked line of sight. On a tabletop someone would have to measure these things after every move, which in turn kills the real-time tension. In Unity this happens every frame. A distance check handles hearing, an angle check and a raycast handle sight a navigation mesh lets the creature path around the furniture and timers handle the sprint lockout and search.

The creature never reads the players position either. It moves to the player's last remembered position, which is what makes hiding a real strategy. Finally, the visuals use the values as the game logic so the player can see what the game is constantly checking.

Playtesting Feedback

Some of my roommates helped me play test this game. The testers played from an instruction card without any help or direction from me while I took notes on how they moved, when they sprinted and what they said. Two issues came up.

The first I noticed with the controls. Several players who were not experienced computer game players were not used to holding Shift while steering with WASD and they said the arrow

keys would feel more natural. This is important because if sprinting is physically awkward players avoid it for comfort rather than strategy. That quiet or fast decision never gets made.

Second was a strategy. After a couple of escapes players found a safe route by going up to the left and grabbing the key then coming back down the same way to the door. Once they figured this out they did not need to hide and rarely sprinted. The fixed layout let them replace the creature with memorization of the path.

Reflection and Iteration

I made a change for each issue. For the controls the arrow keys now move the player and Space sprints while WASD and Left Shift still work. The challenge stays in deciding when to sprint, not in the hand positions.

For the route I randomized the two things players had already memorized. The key now spawns in one of four positions each attempt. The creature picks its patrol point at random instead of walking in a fixed loop. No path is guaranteed safe anymore. Players must watch where the creature is facing and decide whether a gap is worth the noise.

This taught me that players will always look for the solution to repeat even when it makes the game less fun. Randomness was a fix, but it carries a risk. A key that spawns in front of the creature can feel unfair rather than tense.

With time I would:

- Playtest the randomized build to ensure the safe route is gone and to find optimal spawn points
- Guarantee a minimum distance between the key and the creature at the start of each run

- Add hiding spots, such as closets so hiding is an action and not just standing behind a box
- Add throwable objects so noise becomes a tool, for luring the creature away not just the cost of moving fast